



Mostly sunny 51/27 • Tomorrow: Sunny 42/35 **B24**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

SUNDAY, DECEMBER 21, 2025 • **\$6**

Tucker Carlson a thorn for GOP unity

Right-wing provocateur has a big soapbox amid battle for MAGA’s future

BY SARAH ELLISON AND HANNAH KNOWLES

Tucker Carlson had some concerns. So he called President Donald Trump.

The right-wing podcaster and provocateur wanted to understand why the U.S. was attacking alleged drug smuggling boats off the coast of Venezuela, and he warned against pursuing regime change there — a prospect that has alarmed the more isolationist “America First” Republicans in Trump’s movement.

The conversations last weekend, which Carlson recalled in an interview, show how the Fox News castoff is at the center of some of the most heated disputes in MAGA — over foreign policy, antisemitism and conspiracy theories, among other topics heightening tensions in the movement. As the right wrestles with what it should stand for and against in the coming years, Carlson is a divisive and influential figure with an audience — on social media, among MAGA commentators and inside the White House.

Trump doesn’t always heed Carlson’s opinions. The administration ratcheted up pressure on Venezuela in recent days, even as Carlson urged against it. But as a growing number of MAGA activists clash with Trump and each other, clouding the future of the movement, Carlson has become a

SEE CARLSON ON A6

The Sunday Take: Trump’s naming fixation breaks from precedent. **A2**



DEMETRIUS FREEMAN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Jawanna Hardy, founder of the anti-violence group Guns Down Friday, and children look at a car driving by a training at 10th Place.

Federal takeover left lasting marks in D.C.

In a Congress Heights community, residents say law enforcement tactics deepened their mistrust

BY ELLIE SILVERMAN, JOY SUNG, JUAN BENN JR. AND KATIE METTLER

Young men passed around a booming speaker and girls laughed while dancing. Kids raced through the parking lot on Lime bikes, dodging potholes. Maciah King-Brooks, 16, grabbed two hot dogs off the grill.

Then dozens of officers with President Donald Trump’s D.C. Safe and Beautiful Task Force seemed to come from all direc-

tions.

They poured out of unmarked vehicles and ran through the crowd, disrupting the Labor Day weekend cookout at the Southeast Washington apartment complex known as 10th Place. Many officers wore tactical gear. Some carried rifles.

Maciah took out his phone and pressed record, documenting the agencies: FBI. DEA. MPD. U.S. Marshals. Secret Service.

Those at 10th Place are familiar with local police in their

community, where violence has long been an issue and D.C. police said officers have responded to two dozen reports of suspected gunfire in the past year.

On this August night, though, no crime had been reported. The task force officers were there to do a “foot patrol” after seeing a group of about 50 people, according to court documents. But witnesses said it felt more like a raid.

When Trump launched his crime emergency in August — taking over D.C. police for 30

days and deploying National Guard troops and federal law enforcement into city streets — he said he wanted to combat “out of control” crime.

In the months since, 10th Place residents who spoke with The Washington Post said the president’s crime strategy has not fixed their community’s chronic public safety issues.

Despite a dip in violent crime and no reported shootings from Aug. 11 to Sept. 10 in their neighborhood, many said the tactics used by law enforcement

SEE 10TH PLACE ON A8

In a Kansas mall, a late wife’s wintry joy lives on

BY KYLE MELNICK

The hundreds of snowman figurines on display at a Kansas mall might look alike, but each was important to Kathy Allen Duncan.

Some are skiing, others are caroling in front of houses or lounging in the snow made from cotton. A handful are using the bathroom.

For five decades, Kathy created detailed snowman displays in her home with the roughly 1,000 figurines she collected. But the tradition was in peril when Kathy, 73, died in September of complications from diabetes.

Her husband, R.E. “Tuck” Duncan, looked back at photos of Kathy’s displays before her funeral. He recalled thinking, “We need to build one more, one last one.” He wanted to share it not just with his family, but also with all of Topeka, Kansas.

Tuck, 74, rented a vacant store at a local shopping mall where he and other family members created an exhibit showing hundreds of Kathy’s snowmen — which she called “snowpeople” — enjoying the winter. There’s a banner that reads: “KATHY ALLEN DUNCAN’S SNOWPEOPLE VILLAGE.” Another poster shows Kathy’s obituary.

Kathy’s family said their goal was to spread joy — something they said Kathy did daily — to as

SEE SNOWMEN ON A19

U.S. forces board tanker amid Venezuela blockade

BY TARA COPP, KAREN DEYOUG, SAMANTHA SCHMIDT AND ANA VANESSA HERRERO

U.S. forces boarded a commercial vessel off Venezuela early Saturday, days after President Donald Trump announced a “total and complete blockade” on all oil tankers under U.S. sanctions entering or leaving Venezuela as part of the administration’s

mounting pressure campaign against the government of President Nicolás Maduro.

U.S. Coast Guard members boarded the oil tanker Centuries, which the Department of Homeland Security said was “suspected of carrying oil subject to U.S. sanctions.” It was the second ship boarded by U.S. forces off Venezuela this month.

The ship was last docked in Venezuela, Homeland Security

Secretary Kristi L. Noem said. A video she posted on social media shows military helicopters approaching the vessel and then hovering in place as service members rappel down to a deck.

The administration is increasing pressure on Venezuela’s drug trade and economy in a broader effort to force Maduro from office. The U.S. has deployed more than a dozen warships to the Caribbean and eastern Pacific Ocean since

August and launched more than two dozen military strikes on boats that it claims were crewed by “narco-terrorists” smuggling drugs into the U.S. The 27 strikes announced by the administration have killed at least 104 people connected to drug cartels, officials have said. They have not

SEE VENEZUELA ON A15

U.S. options narrow: Campaign against Maduro escalates. **A14**

Complaint to FBI: Files include allegations made in 1990s. **A10**

To save NYC’s flooding subway, officials attack its many leaks

BY SARAH KAPLAN, JOHN MUYSKENS, DANIEL WOLFE AND KEVIN CROWE

Every day, thousands of people walk up two yellow steps, never knowing they are treading on a key tool in the New York subway’s fight against a rising climate threat.

Torrential rainstorms fueled by the warmer atmosphere are increasingly striking the city — creating floods that gush into tunnels and submerge tracks.

At least 200 of the city’s 472 stations have flooded in the past two decades, according to data from the Metropolitan Transit Authority.

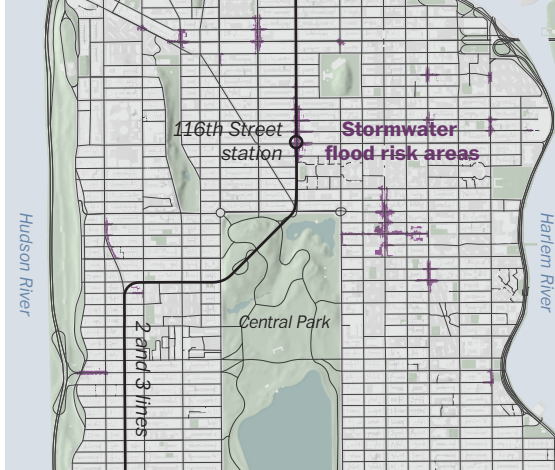
As the planet warms, subway systems in places such as London and Tokyo have struggled to cope with floods far beyond what they were originally designed to handle. Stormwater regularly seeps into the subterranean networks, cutting off the transit lines that

Early 1600s



Note: Flood risks represent a “moderate flood” scenario with rainfall of 2.13 inches per hour. Source: New York Botanical Garden, NYC Department of Environmental Protection

Today



are their cities’ lifeblood. At least 14 passengers were killed in the Chinese city of Zhengzhou four years ago when floodwaters filled their train tunnel.

Few places are more suscep-

ble than New York. The city’s sprawling, century-old subway system was built close to the surface and contains more than 40,000 openings through which water can reach the tracks below.

Its vulnerabilities underground are exacerbated by surging moisture in the skies above, a Washington Post analysis shows. The strongest plumes of water vapor the region sees each year —

which provide fuel for the most severe storms — are intensifying almost twice as much as the global average. Very heavy rainfall events (producing at least 1.4 inches of rain in a day) have increased about 60 percent since the subway was first built.

Yet public transit is also crucial for the fight against rising temperatures, officials say, because it means riders aren’t using cars or trucks that spew planet-warming pollution.

This is what it will take to protect the New York subway — and its nearly 1.2 billion annual riders — in an era of escalating floods.

An aging system

Long before the subway was built, before the city even existed, water defined New York. Manhattan was dotted by ponds and crisscrossed by creeks and streams. Wetlands fringed the Brooklyn and Queens borders,

SEE FLOODING ON A12

SPORTS
Commanders lose another quarterback in 29-18 loss to Eagles. **B1**

THE WORLD
See how the world’s tallest Christmas tree is dressed up. **A24**



TRAVEL
Japan’s exquisite coffee omakase is the nation’s love letter to caffeine.

BUSINESS
We told five AIs to give the Rock hair and delete an ex. See who won. **B11**



ARTS & STYLE
How to fix, remix or erase America’s most offensive monuments.

BOOK WORLD
Small treasures from a literary life dot Geraldine Brooks’s home library.

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The Washington Post / Year 149, No. 54437

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